

GLOSSY GASBAGS

SET Max's new cricket faces are an inadvertent riot act

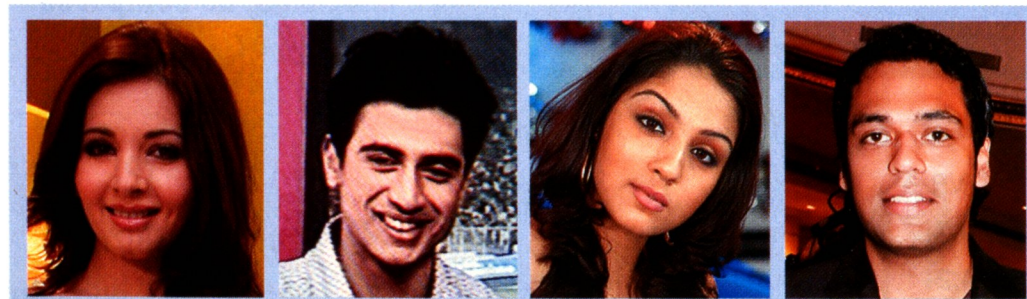
As Kapil Sibal, MP from Chandni Chowk in Delhi, just 1 km away from the Feroz Shah Kotla stadium, walked in to take his place, a bright spark from the SET Max team asked him: "Who are you supporting?" Considering the Delhi Daredevils were playing the Rajasthan Royals, it wasn't surprising that Sibal favoured her with a look he would no doubt reserve for either an opposition MP or a lawyer appearing against him—which may sometimes be the same thing. As India gets used to all the hyperbole and hyperventilating on SET Max during the IPL matches, such inanities are proving to be as entertaining as the goings-on on the field and in the star-studded stands. Questions have been put to officiating umpires about which team they are rooting for, cheerleaders have been ogled at, Gauri Khan has been happily identified as an actor, and even Sunil Gavaskar, the picture of sobriety during his days on ESPN-Star Sports, has taken to shouting into the mike every time someone hits a boundary.

As the Extraaa Innings anchors balance like fidgety widgets on bar stools more suited to party lounges, giggly girls prance around the stadiums gushing about cricket stars. The flibbertygibbets—actor Shiv Pandit, better known for his Sprite commercial, and Samir Kochhar, best known before this

Ganguly and Ricky Ponting had, he said, made him try extra hard to prove himself, "to get some respect from them, to show that you belong here".

The batsmen may be settling down to a feast of sixes, the audience to cheering them and the dancing girls to spurts of pom-pom waving, but the bowlers must believe they are the whipping boys. T20 is a rough version of something that doesn't quite look like justice. Every IPL venue has boundaries pulled closer, averaging no bigger than 65 yards as opposed to 75 for ODIs. "The grounds now look like carromboards to us bowlers," says India spinner Murali Kartik.

With more than a month to go, IPL squads are leaving their carbon footprints across India (if it's Saturday, it must be the Super Kings) every weekend. The franchise's real labour for the long haul will start when the first edi-



LIP SERVICE:
Shonali Nagrani,
Shiv Pandit, Lekha
Washington, Samir
Kochhar

for a sex show on a lifestyle channel which had him playing with molten wax candles and ostrich feathers—wear clothes that look cool on 10-year-olds. Both of them also insist on wearing more lip gloss than the girls. Ajay Jadeja, looking a trifle too old for the job, does his best to please, but is often swatted away even by those whom he flatters. When he said to Vijay Mallya at the opening ceremony that he could celebrate with Kingfisher, Mallya, not known to let a self-promotion opportunity go by, said he could do it with Royal Challenge as well. One presumes all this surrogate advertising will soon come to Dr Killjoy Anbumani Ramadoss's attention but in the meantime even those unconnected with the sponsors are busy pitching for endorsements—Rameez Raja, who found it difficult to recall the names of the teams on day one, had no trouble mentioning the name of the fizzy drink that fellow commentator Robin Jackman was opening in the commentator's box.

SET Max insists all this has been designed with the young audience in mind—so it is surprising that the early ratings show the largest segment of viewers (38 per cent) is those above 35. "These same purists were offended by Mandira Bedi when we first launched her in 2003. And now look at her," says Sneha Rajani, EVP & business head, Max. Er, look at her indeed. Ousted by the latest models who can wear noodle straps better. And to think SET Max auditioned 600 actors/models/anchors before settling on its team of presenters. Give us L. Sivaramakrishnan's easy style and Jackman's crusty comments any day. They may not wear lip gloss and cream foundation but at least they talk cricket. And sense.

by Kaveri Banzai

tion actually ends on June 1. Then, says Hiren Pandit, managing partner, GroupM ESP, franchises will have to activate locally—around sponsors, ticketing, merchandise, local fan clubs. "The IPL is definitely going to work; there will just be some course correction after two months," he says.

Even as it embraces cricket's shiny new spectacle, India might stand some of the IPL's notions on their head. Leaving the Chinnaswamy Stadium on opening night, were Bangalore 20-somethings Noor and Burhan, who had paid Rs 1,300 each for a Rs 500 ticket. They were, Noor said, "more concerned to see Shah Rukh Khan" than the match. The Royal Challengers had been supported, Burhan joked, only as long as Rahul Dravid was at the crease.

Would they come back to the stadium for an IPL game? "If the Kolkata Knight Riders are playing, we sure will."

with Elora Sen